

Mikhail Gorbachev

The Communist who killed off
COMMUNISM in the USSR

All about me

- **BORN:** 1931
- **NATIONALITY:** Russian
- **FACTOID:** I graduated from the Moscow State University Law School in 1955.
- **ANOTHER FACTOID:** I won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1990.
- **IN A NUTSHELL:** I became general secretary of the Communist Party in 1985, and president of the USSR in 1988.

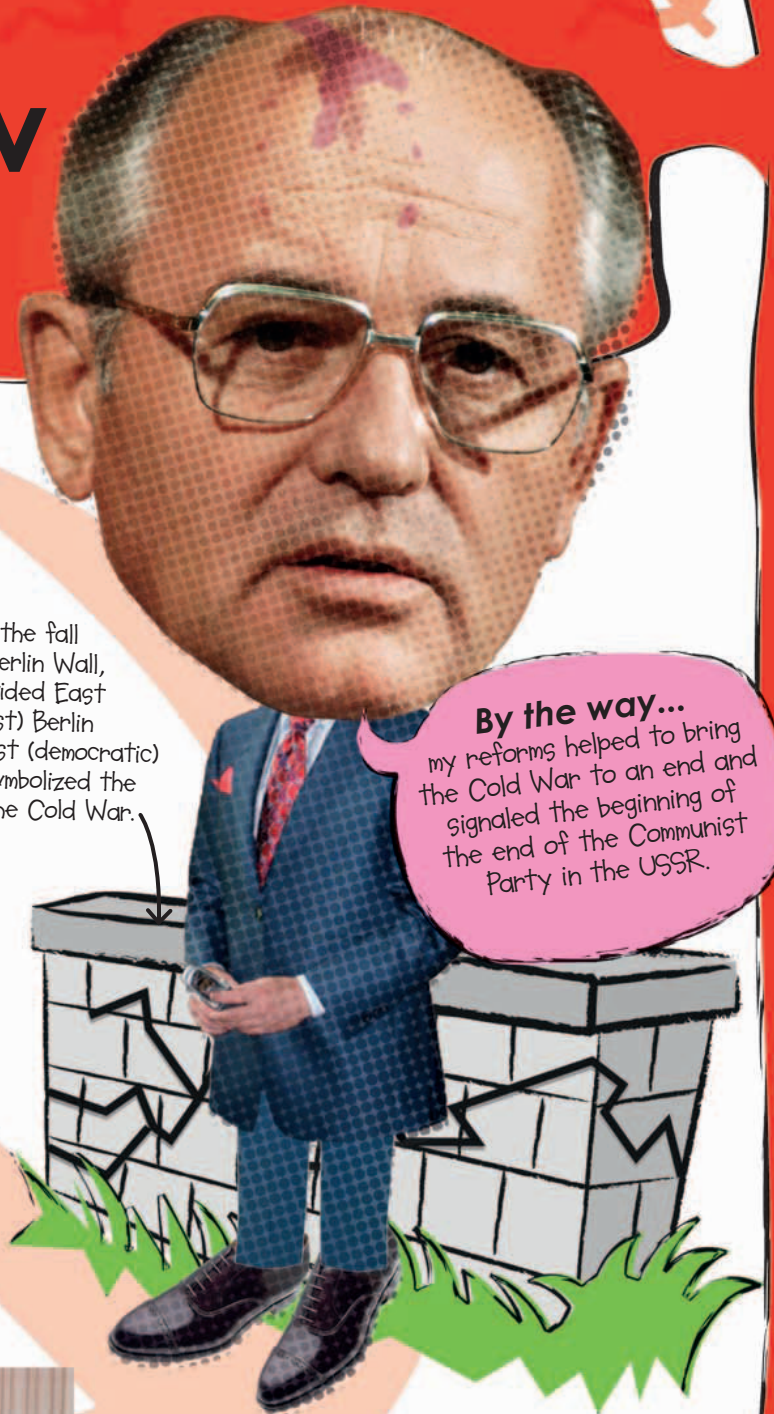
Communism before Gorbachev

The philosopher Karl Marx (1818–1883) said that power should be in the hands of the people and **wealth should be shared equally**. In 1917, Vladimir Lenin (1870–1924) led the **RUSSIAN REVOLUTION** and, in 1922, Russia became the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). Under **Communist rule**, the USSR became closed off from the rest of the world and, by the time Gorbachev took over, its economy was in a mess.

In 1989, the fall of the Berlin Wall, which divided East (communist) Berlin from West (democratic) Berlin, symbolized the end of the Cold War.

By the way...

my reforms helped to bring the Cold War to an end and signaled the beginning of the end of the Communist Party in the USSR.



The radical reformer

Gorbachev reformed the Soviet Union's economy, and **GAVE NEW FREEDOMS** to Soviet citizens. He opened up talks with Western democracies and, in 1987, he struck a deal with America to end the **nuclear arms race**, which signaled an end to the Cold War. The following year he **withdrew Soviet control** in the Eastern Bloc states in Europe, who then overthrew their Communist regimes.